Pakistan joint defense—or some sort of unified effort—possible. Furthermore, it would eliminate a complication from the US-India relationship.[34] Finally, as Secretary of State Dean Rusk noted, Indian efforts toward a settlement would better allow the US to plan for long-term military aid to India and improve congressional sentiments toward India.[35]

From Kennedy on down, the administration believed that it would be tough, if not impossible, to get military aid or further economic assistance for India through Congress if there was no progress between the two countries or if India did not at least make a serious effort.[36] Senate Foreign Relations Committee chairman J. William Fulbright, for example, expressed concern about increasing military supply to India in the absence of a Kashmir settlement.[37] After it became evident that a settlement was unlikely, Komer even suggested urging Delhi to make a move that could place the blame for the failure of talks on Pakistan—thus making it easier to get an aid package for India through Congress.[38]

Was US military aid conditional on a solution? It was clear there was at least a link between long-term aid and efforts toward a solution. As Rusk put it, "While there should be no question of linking between emergency-phase military aid to India and progress on Kashmir … there [is a] definite relationship with longer-run aid."[39] Kennedy also noted that the Indian "attitude toward Pakistan must inevitably be a factor in our long-term military aid plans."[40]

Rusk recognized that linkage was risky.[41] The president also realized that it might be counterproductive. He acknowledged, "no Indian politician could involve his country in negotiations with Pakistan if Indian opinion came to believe that the West was forcing India to give up Kashmir as a price for helping it to save Ladakh or even [the North-East Frontier Agency]." He worried that, in a few months, India would blame the US and UK for pushing it into a corner. There needed to be some movement, however, since "whether we like it or not, the question of Kashmir is inescapably linked to what we can do to assist India militarily."[42]

Linkage was risky for another reason as well: as Kennedy put it, "India would make a deal with the Chinese if we press India on Kashmir."[43] Rusk shared this concern about pushing for too many concessions.[44] Galbraith worried that if it seemed like Kashmir was a bigger concern for Washington than China, then the US would lose Indian willingness to confront China.[45]